



FROM ZERO TO PRO - MODULE 02

Knife Skills & Mise en Place

Knife skills are the highest-leverage skill in cooking; build safe, consistent cuts before speed.

Weeks 3-4 - watch, study, cook, reflect

By the end of this module

- 1 Hold a chef's knife with the pinch grip and use the claw guiding hand.
- 2 Execute the standard cuts: slice, julienne, brunoise, dice, chiffonade, mince.
- 3 Break down an onion, carrot, and herbs cleanly and with minimal waste.
- 4 Hone and understand sharpening; care for your blade.

LESSON 2.1

The Knife and the Grip

Objective: Hold the knife with control using the pinch grip and the guiding claw.

Key points

- Pinch grip on the blade gives control; gripping the handle alone is weak.
- Claw hand: knuckles guide the blade, fingertips tuck safely away.
- Let the knife's weight and curve do the work; do not force it.
- A sharp knife is a safe knife - it does not slip.

Technique

- 1 Pinch**
Thumb on one side of the blade, curled index finger on the other.
- 2 Claw**
Curl guiding fingertips under; rest the blade's flat on your knuckles.
- 3 Rock**
Keep the tip on the board and rock the blade through the cut.
- 4 Walk**
Slide the claw hand back to set the next slice width.

LESSON 2.2

The Standard Cuts

Objective: Produce the classic cuts at consistent dimensions.

Key points

- Julienne = 1/8 inch matchsticks; brunoise = 1/8 inch dice from julienne.
- Batonnet = 1/4 inch sticks; small dice = 1/4 inch cube from batonnet.
- Square off rounded vegetables first so cuts are even and stable.
- Even size beats speed - uniform pieces cook at the same rate.

Technique

- 1 Square off**
Trim a round vegetable into a rectangular block for flat, stable sides.
- 2 Plank**
Slice the block into even slabs.
- 3 Stick**
Stack slabs and cut into sticks (julienne or batonnet).
- 4 Dice**
Line up the sticks and cut across to make cubes.

LESSON 2.3

Breaking Down Aromatics

Objective: Cut onion, garlic, shallot, and herbs cleanly with minimal waste.

Key points

- Cut onions pole to pole and keep the root as a handle to hold layers together.
- Smash garlic with the flat of the blade to skin it, then mince.
- Dice shallots like miniature onions for fine, even aromatics.
- Gather scraps into your garbage bowl to keep the board clear.

Technique

- 1 Halve**
Cut the onion pole to pole through the root and peel.
- 2 Vertical**
Make evenly spaced cuts toward (not through) the root.
- 3 Cross-cut**
Slice across to drop an even dice; spacing sets the size.
- 4 Finish**
Discard the root and gather the dice.

LESSON 2.4

Honing, Sharpening, and Knife Care

Objective: Keep an edge that is sharp, aligned, and safe.

Key points

- Honing realigns the edge (do it often); sharpening removes metal (do it seldom).
- Hand-wash and dry knives right away; the dishwasher ruins edges and handles.
- Cut only on wood or plastic - glass and stone destroy the edge.
- Store on a magnet strip or in-drawer guard, never loose in a drawer.

Watch out for

- Never honing, then wondering why the knife slips and crushes.
- Tossing a good knife in the dishwasher.
- Trying to catch a falling knife - step back and let it drop.

Practice & homework

1

The 5-pound onion drill: dice five onions, aiming for even pieces. Save for soups.

2

Film your grip and one dice; compare to a Pepin demo and note 3 fixes.

3

Prep a full mise en place for one dinner before turning on any burner.

Watch & learn (free)



Gordon Ramsay - How to Master 5 Basic Cooking Skills

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ZJy1ajvMU1k>



Jacques Pepin - Techniques & More (KQED)

<https://www.youtube.com/playlist?list=PL435B8F0CB00AF764>



J. Kenji Lopez-Alt (food science & technique)

<https://www.youtube.com/@JKenjiLopezAlt>



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Next up - Module 03: Heat & Cooking Methods

FROM ZERO TO PRO - THE SELF-TAUGHT CHEF PROGRAM